



AS THE FASTEST
growing genre of
television, news
has in fact been
eating into the
primetime viewing
of popular soaps.

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Battle ZONE

2000 Aaj Tak begins as a 24-hour news channel on December 31, 2000, revolutionising Hindi news. Star Plus also starts its reign. Amitabh Bachchan descends with *Kaun Banega Crorepati* and Smriti Irani's *Tulsi* becomes iconic.

2003 Star News, an all-day Hindi news channel, is launched. Days later, NDTV begins India's first 24-hour English news channel, NDTV 24x7.

2008 Colors launches. Within 10 months, it topples Star Plus from the No. 1 position after nine years. *Balika Vadhu* becomes the new soap sensation.



2009 Reality TV finds its footing. *Bigg Boss*, *Rakhi Ka Swayamvar*, *Khatron Ke Khiladi* and *Sach Ka Saamna* all push the envelope.

spirit of india special ■

complete contrast to the government-funded Doordarshan that is under no financial pressure to change its anodyne presentations or compete with others in the market. Although the English language news channels stick to their brief and devote nearly 85 per cent of their air-time to news and analysis, many regional news channels offer a 'magazine' format with just around 40 per cent of the content devoted to political news. The rest is a confection of sport, crime, and 'human interest' stories, the latter generally involving sensationalised accounts of alleged miracles by local deities or holy men and freak accidents. Cinema and trivia about celebrities also provide cost-effective padding to news bulletins as they are cheaper to assemble than in-depth reports.

Undoubtedly, the problem of capturing a viewer's interest is a universal one, and can, sometimes, result in acts of sheer desperation—such as in Italy, where on one channel, 'newsreaders' take off an item of clothing on completion of each item of news. Despite howls of protest from the intelligentsia at this apparent 'dumbing down' of content, the growth of news channels and their viewers (as verified by TRPS) continues unabated. This indicates a vibrant interest in politics and a citizenry keen to engage with the democratic process, as against the boredom that plagues politics in the post-industrial world. Yet the frenetic scramble for news channels, and the demands made by advertisers on their contents, have uncovered serious flaws, as evidenced in the television coverage of the 26/11 attacks. Unrestricted, live footage of the attacks and the blazoning of sensitive information about the arrival of the rescue teams helped terrorists plan their action.

Just as India transforms itself from a largely agricultural economy into a manufacturing and technological giant, satellite television too is moving from adolescence to adulthood. At some point in the future, a saturation point for news channels will be reached, followed by a shake-out of excess capacity. Hopefully, stabilisation of the industry will bring forth more considered content and reporting, and then, Indian television news will truly come of age.

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proliferation of regional channels. Without a charismatic, national figure to dominate the national news agenda, the top-down news transmissions from the centre have transformed into ones that are based on immediate regional and local concerns.

There are 130 million TV households in India of which over 90 million are cable and satellite. Though the big news in television is the 'vernacularisation' and regionalisation of news channels, local news continues to be delivered, not by local agencies, but by the large national and international media moguls. This is because the business of TV news is extremely lucrative.

Uniquely in India, satellite television is delivered by cable. With dodgy accounting and unverifiable subscription figures from cablewallahs, media companies depend on advertising for their revenues. It is estimated that around 70 per cent of a channel's revenues emanate from advertising with just 30 per cent from subscriptions.

News channels are in competition, not just with other news channels but also 'reality' programmes, and the overdressed, emotionally overwrought soaps. This is in